The Wrench Studios presents

THE ICEBOX

Written by Master Freeze

Issue #9: Gunpei Yokoi

Gunpei Yokoi (横井軍平) was a man with an imaginative mind and creative skills that have influenced generations of toys and video games. He is most famously known for carrying Nintendo into the world of toys and video games. He invented the D-pad, Game & Watch, Game Boy, and Virtual Boy. He was the head of the early “Nintendo Research & Development Team” that designed the first arcade games under Nintendo.

Mr. Yokoi’s résumé and contributions to video games is not just impressive, but generational and legendary. His story is all the more inspiring, and I think it is worth sharing. Even though I was born long after he left this world, I continue to enjoy video games and inventions that sprouted from his creative mind.

While you can certainly read his story on Wikipedia or the likes, I want to share an abridged version of Mr. Yokoi’s story. He was born in 1941 and raised in Kyoto, and graduated from Doshisha University with a degree in electronics.

In 1965, at 24 years old, he was hired by Nintendo president Hiroshi Yamauchi to manage the machinery behind Nintendo’s Hanafuda card assembly. Back then, Nintendo was a company that sold playing cards. Some people claim that Nintendo would have failed as a company if they didn’t sell Hanafuda cards, and even that would have soon become outdated with novel technologies replacing physical games.

Needless to say, Mr. Yokoi’s work was dull and monotonous. He spent his spare time repurposing scraps into toys, one of them being an extending arm that he designed purely for his own entertainment.

Mr. Yamauchi actually noticed this very toy and made an order to have it turned into a marketed product as a strategic move for the end of 1966. In 1964, the Tokyo Olympics took place, bringing popularization to the gymnastics concept of “Ultra C”. Yamauichi’s marketing genius led him to name Yokoi’s toy, “Ultra Hand”.

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The Ultra Hand sold over a million units in 1966, which was a time where even selling a hundred thousands units was considered a success. Mr. Yokoi was quickly moved from maintenance duty to full-time product development, where his genius was allowed to unfold and carve the path for the future of Nintendo.

It is also important to note the influence of Ultra Hand itself. The actual toy has appeared in multiple video games, such as Mario Power Tennis, WarioWare, and Mario Kart 8 Deluxe. You may have also noticed that one of the powers that Link acquires from Rauru's arm, in the game Tears of the Kingdom, is called Ultrahand.

Mr. Yokoi went on to produce even more successful toys, such as Ultra Machine, Ten Billion Barrel, Chiritorie the remote-controlled vacuum, and Nintendo's Love Tester. All of these toys were big hits in Japan, with the Ultra Hand making it so far as to be sold into the borders of Australia during Nintendo's early rise. Mr. Yokoi's toy-creating continued until 1974, when Nintendo shifted its focus onto video games.

As mentioned before, Mr. Yokoi became the head of Nintendo Research & Development, focusing on video games. Mr. Yokoi's contributions to the early video game industry are still upheld to this day by companies around the world.

One day, when Mr. Yokoi was riding a shinkansen (新幹線), or bullet train, he noticed a businessman idly fidgeting with the buttons of a calculator. Immediately, a lightbulb flashed in the creative mind of Gunpei Yokoi. He thought, "What if you could play a game on a calculator?"

In order to understand the logic behind his next steps, you should understand that Mr. Yokoi famously followed his own philosophy in invention:

枯れた技術の水平思考
"Lateral thinking of withered technology."

Basically, he advocated for repurposing old and cheaper technology with brand-new, creative uses. This is just how he had invented the Ultra Hand!

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Mr. Yokoi envisioned the repurposing of the LCD screen for the creation of his most iconic device, which was also the first handheld device made by Nintendo, the company that excels at portable video game technologies.

The device had two main functions, one game and a built-in clock. Many variations were produced of this device to feature a different game, since this was before the idea of game cartridges.

The device was called, Game & Watch, and it was Nintendo's first global success in electronics. The Game & Watch line sold 43.4 million units, instantly clearing Nintendo's outstanding debts and placing them in the spotlight for the video game market, which was beginning to grow rapidly due to the physical arcade.



Mr. Yokoi was then asked by Nintendo president Yamauchi to supervise Shigeru Miyamoto, the man who created Donkey Kong, Mario Bros., and later Zelda games. Mr Yokoi himself led the development of the NES Zapper and R.O.B., both accessories for the NES console and pivotal for Nintendo's unique style.

If you haven't connected the dots yet, Mr. Yokoi is the very reason that Nintendo secured its place as the most legendary video game company of all time. He has contributed to the smooth transition between toys and video games using his philosophy, and without his genius imagination the world would miss the touch of magic that he has brought through his inventions.

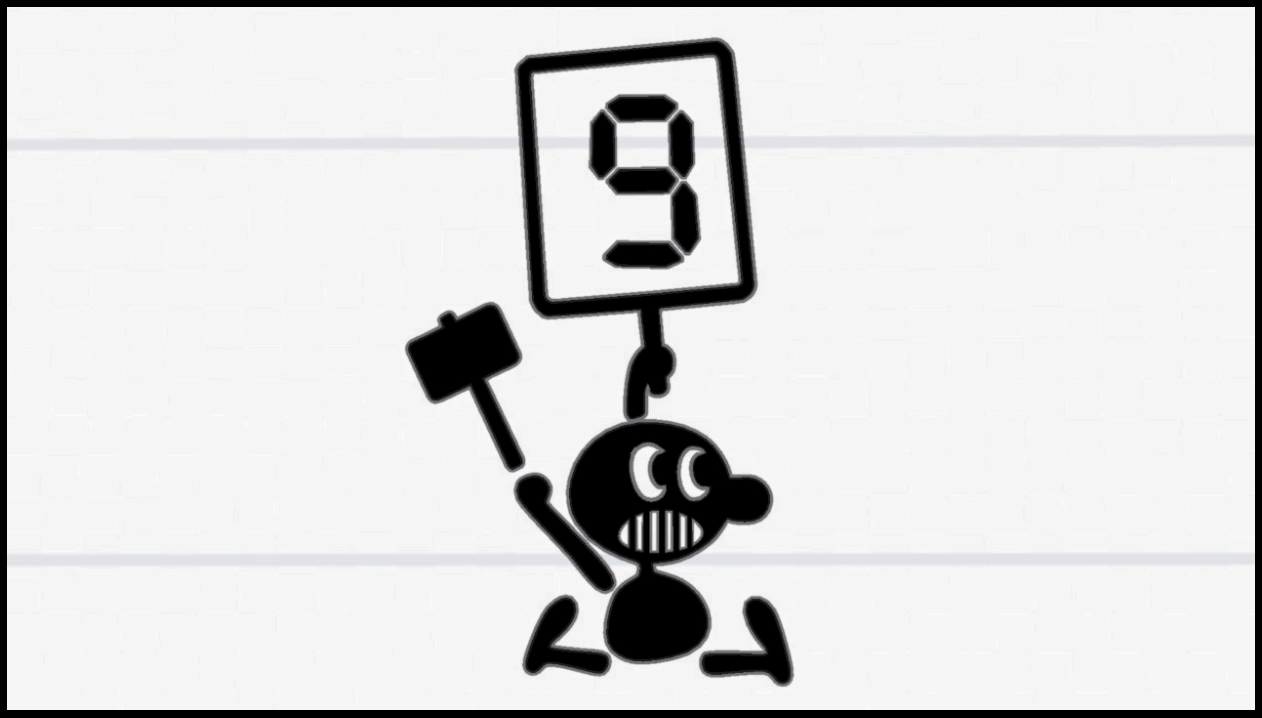
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When you hear, “Game & Watch” you probably think about the little guy from Super Smash Bros., named “Mr. Game & Watch.” He is the game series’ mascot and actually the first video game character in history (counting animated figures), debuting just months before Pac-Man.

Did you notice that this is Issue #9 of the Icebox? Yes, that was intentional!



I have not outlined all of Mr. Yokoi’s contributions. There are many more stories and ideas that the man had that are worth exploring. Mr. Yokoi actually resigned from Nintendo in 1996 after the release of the Game Boy Pocket. There were rumors that he resigned to atone for the failure of the Virtual Boy, which was essentially the earliest version of a VR that flopped. However, president Yamauchi himself rejected the rumors, instead praising Yokoi’s work. Nintendo continued to thrive off of his contributions while Yokoi established Koto Laboratory, ignoring his lifelong plans to retire by 50.

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Unfortunately, Gunpei Yokoi passed away in 1997 at 56 years old due to a traffic accident, before he could see Koto Laboratory release a console called WonderSwan and a line of puzzle games called “Gunpey” made in his honor and published by Bandai.

Gunpei Yokoi was a legendary developer who just wanted to create fun for people to enjoy. We should all carry on his legacy by supporting his philosophies!]



横井軍平 (Gunpei Yokoi)
9/10/1941 - 10/4/1997